



WeChat suspends new users

WeChat is suspending new user registrations until early August due to security reasons. <https://digit.in/aug21-07>



Apple devices may go notch-less?

Rumours suggest that that iPhone 14 will be notch-less, with in-screen Touch ID or/and Face ID. <https://digit.in/aug21-08>

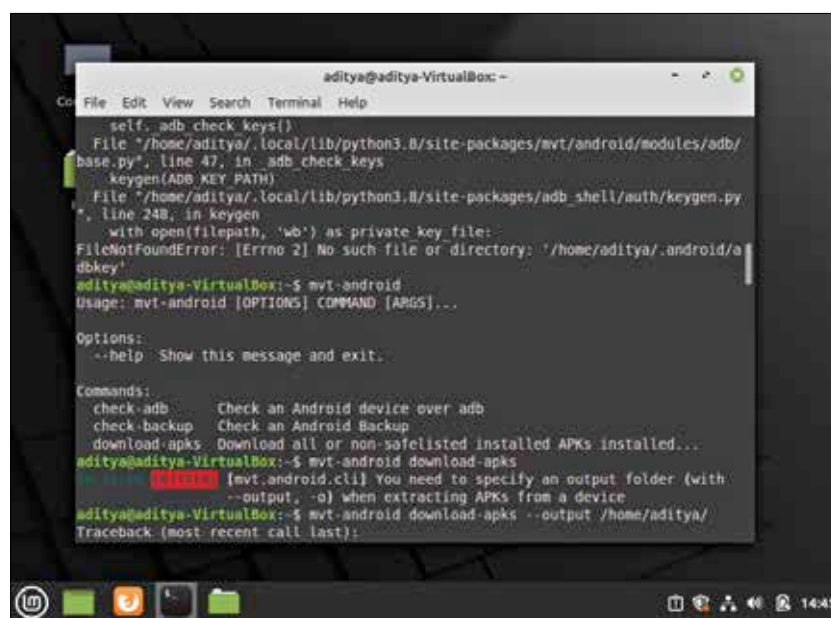
even after a factory reset, not using the infected phone is the only other way to prevent attack – and that requires one to even know there is an issue in the first place.” Mali also told us to junk or refresh the device, “I feel phone formatting and reinstalling the OS at the service centre is the better option. Apps like ‘Lookout’ can help to detect the Pegasus spyware too.”

Mahadeshwar also told us how to be careful of infections by a wide range of spyware, including Pegasus, “beware of phishing links, which are basically suspicious links that, once clicked upon, hacks the user’s phones. Install a robust cybersecurity app and ensure that it is updated. One simple way is to have a pin enabled lock system, or better, a fingerprint enabled lock system, which helps to limit the physical access to the device. Open Wi-Fi connections can be a huge source of attack by hackers. One of the simplest things you can do is use apps that ensure you are connected to a reliable Wi-Fi Security network. You can use data encryption to protect your confidential files from being attacked and encrypted by hackers.”

The Citizen Lab tracks threat actors around the world known to use the spyware, and while there is a threat actor in the subcontinent code-named Ganges, the platform comes at a very high price. Each installation or infection is charged, and the reported rates in 2016 varied from around \$25,000 (Lookout) to \$65,000 (NYT). It is still expected to be incredibly expensive, though the tracked threat actors seem to buy batches or bundles of licenses, the platform is only available to world governments. When we asked how worried should a regular user in a non critical job be of such spyware, Mali told us, “take it from me, installing, monitoring Pegasus is a costly affair which any government will not spend on the common man, if you are a common man like me don’t overthink, and don’t worry. If you are special just get a new phone and don’t click on sms with links

without confirming the links on virustotal.com website.” Krishnapur was reassuring when it came to an infection by Pegasus being unlikely, but warned us about other malware, “most people are unlikely to be targeted by this attack (Pegasus) and there are still simple steps to minimise potential exposure — not only to Pegasus but other spyware too. Best practices and basic due diligence can be followed, such as - not clicking on unverified links or downloading files from an unknown sender, regularly installing device patches and upgrades, encrypting device data and enabling remote-wipe features, not visiting websites that don’t use the HTTPs protocol and avoiding use of public and free Wi-Fi services when accessing sensitive personal informa-

While Pegasus is an extremely targeted threat, the run of the mill ransomware, malware and spyware that spread a wider net are an escalating threat in times of rapid digitisation. Mahadeshwar tells us, “cybercrime has become a huge nuisance since the pandemic began. While everyone is dependent on the work from home scenario, the dependency on technology has increased significantly.” Krishnapur also told us about spyware in general being extra malicious, “when it comes to spyware in particular, threat actors have evolved their techniques to break through strong defence mechanisms which are programmed into most anti-spyware security solutions. Some recent attacks have demonstrated that endpoints running on legacy or unpatched



Using MVT on a Droid

tion.” Krishnapur goes on to explain, “While the threat is undoubtedly real, one should understand that it is not very commonly distributed like typical viruses and trojans. It requires significant time to find security holes and takes effort to build the spyware such as Pegasus. Also, such spyware is usually targeted to minimise detection and maximise impact and hence mostly low risk to most common users.”

Windows OS are highly vulnerable to spyware attacks. In the wrong hands, such advanced spyware could be used to exploit and gain access to sensitive data that is crucial to national security and governance, having implications that are far beyond a traditional breach.” So the important things for users to keep in mind to protect yourself from spies on your device, is keep your devices updated, and don’t tap on fishy links.